Self-Other Miscalibration in Sponsorship Perceptions

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1 INTRODUCTION

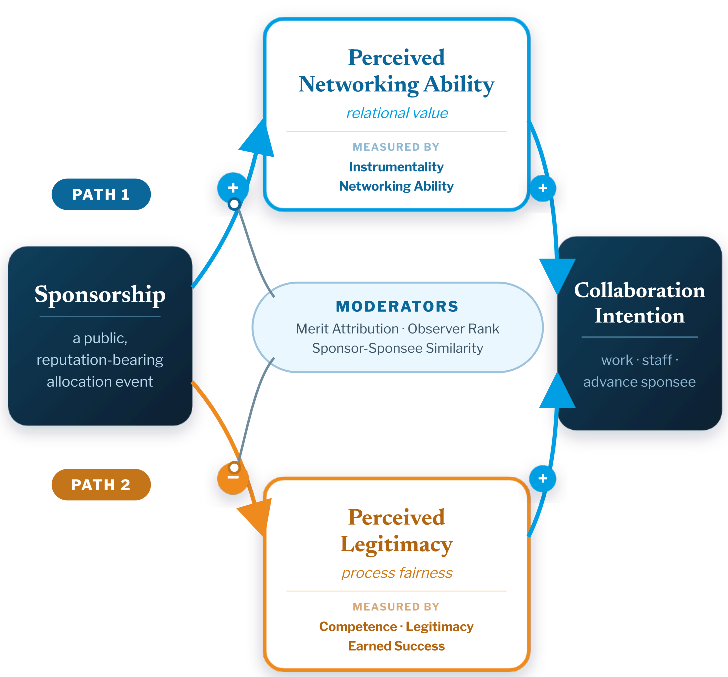
Sponsorship is third-party advocacy that places a candidate into a concrete opportunity, putting the sponsor's own reputation at risk; it has long been recognized as central to career advancement. By drawing on social capital, it gives the sponsee access to information, influence, and opportunity, and is typically framed as a career benefit.

Yet sponsorship is also an **ambiguous signal**: it conveys relational value, such as network utility, political cover, and reach, while simultaneously raising doubts about the sponsee's competence and the legitimacy of the relationship itself. Observers facing this ambiguity tend to lean on the signal and related heuristics when forming judgments, shaping how the sponsee is ultimately received.

? RESEARCH QUESTION

How do sponsees and third-party observers diverge in interpreting a sponsorship event – and how does that divergence shape observers' willingness to collaborate with the sponsee?

2 THEORETICAL MODEL



- Observers weigh sponsorship's **relational value** (Path 1) against its **process fairness** (Path 2); moderators shift which pathway dominates.

Study 1 SELF-OTHER MISCALIBRATION

N = 150 · Prolific | 3 perspectives | Between-subjects

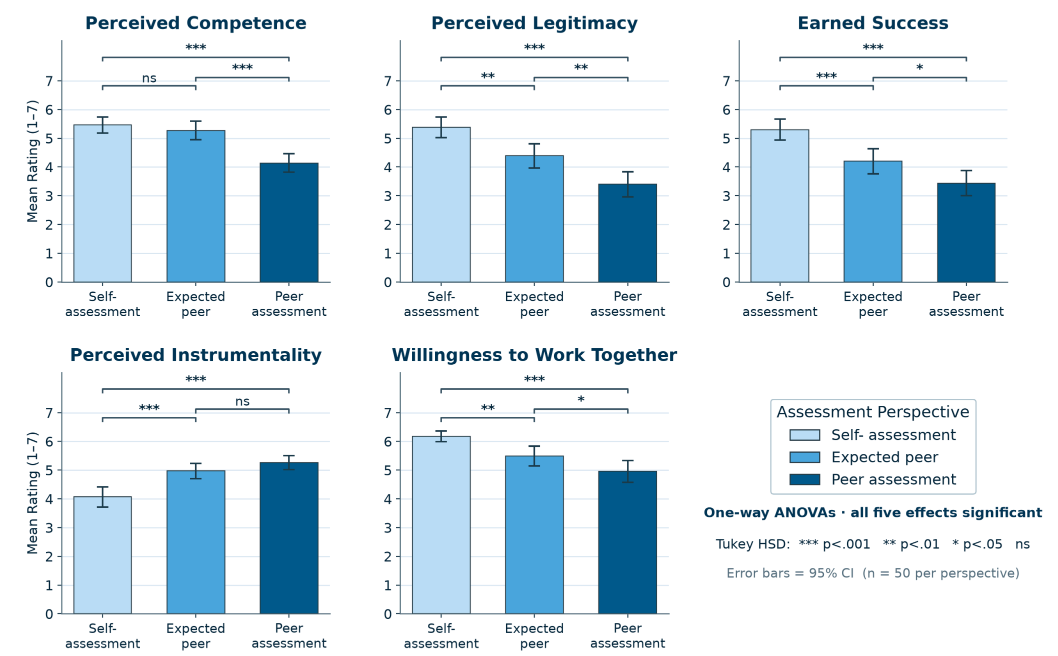


Figure 1. Evaluations across assessment perspective. Self > expected peer > peer for **competence**, **legitimacy**, **earned success** & willingness, while **instrumentality** reverses. One-way ANOVAs; all five effects significant.

- $N = 150$, Prolific; one identical sponsorship scenario
- Randomly assigned to one of three vantage points: **self** (sponsee's own assessment), **expected peer** (sponsee's metaperception), or **peer** (uninvolved observer's direct assessment)
- All groups rated the same five outcomes; one-way ANOVAs compared the three vantage points

★ **Takeaway:** From self to expected peer to peer, ratings drop on **competence**, **legitimacy**, and **earned success**, while **instrumentality** rises. Sponsees see their advancement as earned and fair; observers credit relational value (Path 1) but discount process fairness (Path 2) more than sponsees expect.

Study 2 PILOT · OBSERVER RANK

N = 86 students | Peer vs. Superior | Between-subjects

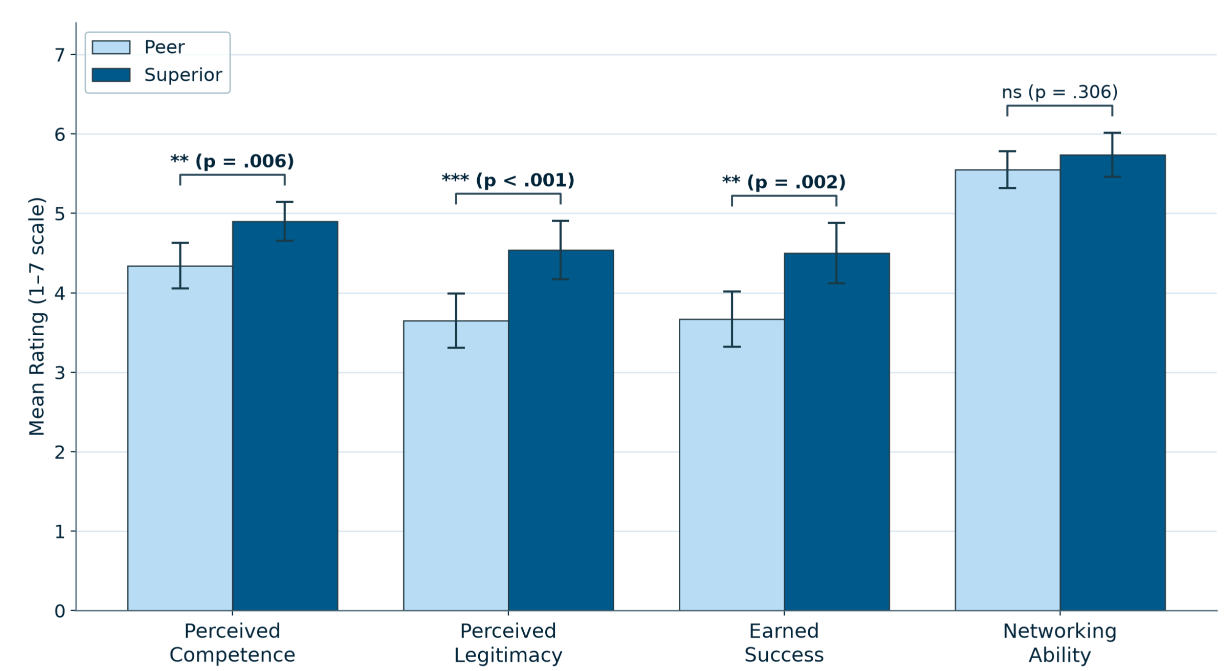


Figure 2. Superiors rate the sponsee higher on **competence**, **legitimacy** & **earned success**, but **networking ability** does not differ. Error bars = 95% CI.

- $N = 86$ business students; pilot testing observer rank
- Same scenario, randomly assigned to rate as a **peer** (fellow junior analyst) or a **superior** (sponsee's engagement manager)
- Independent-samples t-tests compared the two rank conditions

★ **Takeaway:** Superiors rated the sponsee significantly higher than peers on **competence**, **legitimacy**, and **earned success**, but **networking ability** showed no rank difference. Rank shifts the **fairness pathway (Path 2)** specifically, while **relational value (Path 1)** stays untouched.

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SELECTED REFERENCES

Campbell & Shea (2025) · Casciaro & Lobo (2008) · Conlon et al. (2004) · Connelly et al. (2011) · Ferris et al. (2005) · Hewlett (2013) · Ibarra et al. (2010) · Kelley (1973) · Lind (2001) · Pronin et al. (2004) · Spence (1973) · Tyler (2006). Full reference list & study materials available on request.